

» T20 WORLD CUP BUMPER GROUP D



Blazing a trail: In blistering BBL form — 466 runs at 42.36 and striking at 184.18 — Finn Allen now carries serious momentum into New Zealand's T20 World Cup campaign. AP

A crowded doorway

Three contenders, two places, **no margin for error.** Group D pits New Zealand, South Africa and Afghanistan in a format that guarantees one credible side will be gone early.

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Fewer heavyweight clashes in the revamped group-stage format, featuring more Associate nations, might have eroded the high-stakes charm of a T20 World Cup, but the 2026 group phase still has crowd-pulling games in the offing. With South Africa, New Zealand

and Afghanistan pitted together, Group D is the metaphorical 'group of death' this iteration has to offer. Since only two teams advance to the Super Eights, one of these three will crash out in the first stage itself. Canada and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) complete the five-team group.

Out of the big three, New Zealand has been the most consistent since the last World Cup, winning 15 of its 27 games. Mitchell Santner's side will be hoping to ride this momentum to advance in the competition and banish the demons of its group-stage exit in 2024.

The Kiwis' resurgence has hinged